SEND WITH THE SCRIPT

Self-recording guide

Reality-TV confessional style: you sit and talk to the camera, deadpan. No interviewer, so prop up your own phone, or let whoever sent you this hold it, and record it in five minutes whenever you have a free moment.

Setup

- **Nobody films you.** Prop your phone horizontal against a stack of books or a mug, at face height, about an arm's length away. Sit in a chair against a plain wall or a bookshelf.
- **Light:** face a window or a lamp. Don't sit with a window behind you.
- **Eyeline:** look just to the side of the lens, as if a producer is sitting next to the phone. Glancing at the lens once or twice is fine.
- **Tone:** deadpan beats hammy. You are a sincere person who has nothing to hide and is slightly annoyed to be asked.

Recording

- **The script:** read it from a second screen or a printout taped just under the phone. The *(beat)* and *(pause)* marks are where the laughs live. Hold them longer than feels natural.
- **Takes:** two max. Send the slightly flubbed one. Don't edit anything.
- **Length:** 60 to 90 seconds. Start recording, wait two seconds, begin. Stop two seconds after the last line.
- **Send it:** text or AirDrop the raw video to whoever sent you the script. They add the title card and load it onto the classroom laptop.

Making the script yours

Words in [brackets] are adjustable. The facts the kids check (shoe size, where you were, what you wore, how you feel about squishies) live on your **Suspect Statement form**, not in this video; your answer card tells you what to write there. The box at the top of your script lists the one or two things the video has to agree with, and the lines you should keep word for word. Everything else is flavor. Swap in your real life, your real subject, your real habits. Wear whatever you like. True details get the biggest laughs.

The ask (email or text to each suspect)

Subject: 5 minutes of acting for the 4th grade Halloween party?

Hi [Name],

Mrs. Driscoll's class Halloween party on Oct 30 is a whodunit, and the kids are going to investigate four staff "suspects." Would you be one of the three who record a statement? All it takes is a 90-second video of yourself that you can record alone on your phone whenever you have a free minute. No one films you, no one edits you, and you don't need to attend the party.

Attached are your script and a one-page Suspect Statement form with an answer card. Four answers on the form are scripted so the kids' clues line up; the rest is yours, and true is funnier. The video is a monologue, so just talk to the camera. Quick tips:
• Phone horizontal, propped at face height, plain wall behind you
• Look just beside the lens, like a producer is sitting there
• Deadpan. Sincere. Slightly annoyed to be asked.
• Hold the pauses. Two takes max. Send me the raw video and the filled-in form by [Oct 23].

The kids will watch it on the projector during the party and, I promise, lose their minds. Thank you!

[Your name] · [room parent for Mrs. Driscoll's class] · [phone]

The Custodian gets a different ask: "You're a suspect who declined to comment. That's it. That's the whole job. Please act shifty in the hallway on Oct 30."

VIDEO 1 · PLAYS AFTER STATION 1

VIDEO 1 — THE PRINCIPAL

self-recorded monologue, ~90 sec · The only interview with real information, and it arrives by accident. Deadpan. Hold the beats.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 1 · THE PRINCIPAL · 9:12 AM

MAKE IT YOURS (read before you record)

- Your facts (shoe size, what you wore, and so on) live on your Suspect Statement form; the answer card tells you what to write there. On camera only two things have to agree with the form: you were "at a meeting" at [2:15], and you own exactly one squishy, [a cat]. Want a different squishy? Change it on the form too, and tell the room parent.
- Must match the real jar: "the big one, on the high shelf [by the window], with [three] strips of tape." Describe the actual jar in the actual spot.
- Free to change: [four minutes], the kind of meeting, [tie or collar], what the squishy is for. Add one true detail about yourself; it lands harder.
- Keep exactly: saying "squishies" by accident, then "candy," then trying to un-say it. That slip is the whole party.

Words in [brackets] are yours to adjust. Say them naturally, without the brackets.

(Sit. Look just beside the camera. Check your watch.)

I have a meeting in [four minutes], so let's make this quick.

You want to know where I was yesterday at [2:15]. I was in a meeting. I'm always in a meeting. Yesterday it was a meeting about the next meeting.

And you want to know what I know about the missing candy. Let me be very clear about this. I have not heard ANYTHING, and I know NOTHING, about anyone stealing the squishies.

(beat)

I mean candy.

(beat)

...Did I say squishies? What was I thinking! Candy. The candy. I know nothing about the candy.

(pause. Straighten your [tie or collar].)

I did not say squishies. I may have said squishies. It's a very common word. People say it all the time. In meetings. I am the principal of this school. I say a lot of words every day. Statistically, some of them are going to be "squishies."

(too fast)

And for the record, I have never even seen that jar. The big one. On the high shelf [by the window]. With the [three] strips of tape on the lid and the label that says "do not open."

(realize what you just said)

...Which I can only describe because people have described it to me. In meetings.

(pause)

Do I own any squishies myself? I'm the principal.

(beat)

...One. It's [a cat]. It's on my desk. It's for stress. This is stressful. (look at watch) I'm late.

(Stand up and walk out of frame. Leave the phone recording for 3 more seconds, then say, from off camera, slightly muffled:)

Is it off? Did it get the squishy thing? ...Can we cut the squishy thing?

(Then stop recording.)

Two takes max. Send the slightly flubbed one.

VIDEO 2 · PLAYS AFTER STATION 2

VIDEO 2 — THE GYM TEACHER

self-recorded monologue, ~75 sec · Zero information. Genuinely does not understand squishies and is a little offended to be asked.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 2 · THE GYM TEACHER · 11:05 AM

MAKE IT YOURS (read before you record)

- Your facts live on your Suspect Statement form (answer card attached). On camera, two things have to agree with it: you were in the gym, in the building, at [2:15], and you genuinely don't get squishies. Nothing you wear matters, here or at the party.
- Linked to another clue: the [foam avocado] squishy. The mummy's witness statement and the Chief's confession both mention the avocado one. Change it only if the room parent changes those too.
- Free to change: [dodgeball] (whatever unit you're actually teaching), [inflating/deflating things], [jump rope], [the cones]. Swap in your real gym life.
- Keep exactly: "I just don't understand the obsession these days." The kids will quote it.

Words in [brackets] are yours to adjust. Say them naturally, without the brackets.

(Sit. Whistle around your neck if you have one. Look just beside the camera. You are missing a [dodgeball] unit for this.)

I'm missing a [dodgeball] unit for this, so.

Where was I at [2:15] yesterday? Gym. Where I always am. [Inflating things. Deflating things.] The cycle of life.

Did I go near Mrs. Driscoll's room? I go near every room. The hallway is my warm-up lap.

(long sigh)

Okay. Can I say something about these squishies? I don't see what these kids see in squishies anyway. You squeeze it. It goes back. You squeeze it again. It goes back again. That's it. That's the whole thing. I just don't understand the obsession these days.

(beat)

So no, I didn't take that jar. Why would I take a whole jar of something I don't understand? You want to steal something, steal a good [jump rope]. Those are valuable.

(pause)

And before anyone asks: yes, I have a key to the equipment closet. I have a key to every closet. Nobody's accusing me of stealing [the cones]. (look back up) Are you writing that down?

(beat)

Last thing. Whoever has those squishies: there's a whole class of kids out there who can run a mile but can't go a day without squeezing a [foam avocado]. Think about that.

(stand up)

I'm going back to the gym.

(Walk out of frame. Stop recording.)

VIDEO 3 · PLAYS AFTER STATION 3

VIDEO 3 — THE LIBRARIAN

self-recorded monologue, ~75 sec, WHISPERED throughout · Zero information, whispered throughout. Accidentally sounds guilty three times.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 3 · THE LIBRARIAN · 12:30 PM

MAKE IT YOURS (read before you record)

- Your facts live on your Suspect Statement form (answer card attached). On camera, two things have to agree with it: you were in the building at [2:15] (your [2:00 to 2:30] shelving window has to include it), and you love squishies. Your shoe size is on the form and it is what clears you, so don't say a number on camera. Wear whatever you like.
- Free to change: [shelving] (any solo task you really do), [on every cart], why it's stressful, [alphabetized] (any librarian joke you like better).
- Keep exactly: "Whoever took them… check their feet." It points the kids at the footprint clue.

Words in [brackets] are yours to adjust. Say them naturally, without the brackets.

(Sit. Whisper the entire thing, as if you're still in the library. Look just beside the camera.)

(whispering) I know I don't have to whisper. It's a habit.

Where was I at [2:15] yesterday? [Shelving]. I [shelve] from [2:00 to 2:30] every day. Alone. In the back. With no witnesses.

(pause)

That sounded worse than I meant it to.

Did I see anyone near Mrs. Driscoll's room? I saw someone in the hallway. Moving quickly. Carrying something. Hugging it, actually. Like a puppy.

(beat. Close your eyes.)

…I also hug things. Books, mostly.

(pause)

Do I like squishies? I love squishies. I have a squishy [on every cart]. They're very good for stress. [Shelving] is stressful. People put books back in the wrong place on purpose.

(beat. Realize how all of that sounded.)

So, to summarize: I had motive, I had access, and I hug things.

(long pause)

I'd like to amend my earlier statements.

(beat)

No. I did not take the squishies. But if I had, they would be [alphabetized] by now.

(lean in toward the camera, whisper even quieter)

One more thing for the detectives. Whoever took them… check their feet.

(sit back)

I don't know why I said that. I just felt like a detective would say that.

(Stand, push the chair in silently, walk out of frame. Stop recording.)

VIDEO 4 · PLAYS AFTER THE ARREST WARRANTS ARE READ

VIDEO 4 — THE CONFESSION — THE CHIEF

self-recorded monologue, ~90 sec · Starts defensive, cracks fast, ends with the location of the loot.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 4 · THE CHIEF · 1:15 PM · (recorded under protest)

MAKE IT YOURS (read before you record)

- You match every clue on paper: your Suspect Statement form (answer card attached; it stays hidden until deliberation) says size [10], in the building at [2:15], an orange sweater, and loves squishies. On camera you repeat those, and that is enough; you don't have to own anything orange. If you want a visual tell at the party, wear anything orange, even a scarf from the bin. If any of these should change, tell the room parent before anything is printed; the footprint, the ransom note, the posters, the forms, and the case file change together.
- Linked to other clues: "squeezed one and whispered 'so satisfying'" is Squad Nightshade's witness statement; [the avocado one] is in Squad Specter's statement and the Gym Teacher's video. Keep both.
- Must match the Principal: "[He] walked in on me" and "[he] said squishies in a MEETING once." Use the Principal's real pronoun; the slip in Video 1 only works if the Principal is the one who knew.
- Free to change: [twenty] (the real class size), [a math lesson] and [fractions] (whatever you were actually teaching), "I live here, basically."
- Keep exactly: "It IS satisfying, though," "a swamp that's learning fractions" (or your subject), and the last four lines. "A very special light" is the cue for the blacklight finale.

Words in [brackets] are yours to adjust. Say them naturally, without the brackets.

(Sit. Arms crossed. Look just beside the camera. You are offended to be here.)

I want it on the record that I am not a suspect. I'm the Chief. The Chief is never a suspect. That's how it works.

(beat)

Yes, my shoes are a size [10]. Lots of people are a size [10].

Yes, I was in the building at [2:15]. I'm a teacher. I'm always in the building. I live here, basically.

(beat)

Yes, I own an orange sweater. ...It's festive.

(pause)

And yes, I heard what the witness said. That the thief squeezed one and whispered "so satisfying."

(very long pause. Quietly:)

It IS satisfying, though.

(beat. Uncross your arms. Exhale.)

Fine. FINE. It was me. I took the jar. And yes, it was squishies. It was always squishies. Do you know why I labeled it "candy"? Because if I had labeled it "squishies," that jar would have lasted eleven minutes. Do you know what it's like to teach [a math lesson] while [twenty] squishies get squeezed in rhythm? It sounds like a swamp. A swamp that's learning [fractions].

So I didn't steal it. I RELOCATED it. For safekeeping. From myself, mostly.

(wince)

And yes, the Principal knew. [He] walked in on me. Mid-relocation. Arms full. I gave [him] [the avocado one] to keep quiet. Clearly that didn't work. [He's] terrible at secrets. [He] said "squishies" in a MEETING once.

(lean in, almost proud)

Where are they now? Somewhere in that room. In plain sight. Hidden the only way a teacher knows how.

(beat)

You'd need a very special light to see them.

(look right into the lens for the first time)

Nice work, detectives. Now go find them.

(beat)

And if anyone squeezes one during math on Monday, I will do it again.

(Reach toward the camera and stop recording.)

Two takes max. Send the slightly flubbed one.

TIES THE CLUES TO THE SUSPECTS

Suspect statement forms

A one-page questionnaire each suspect fills in by hand. Four of its answers are the four traits the clues test, and we script those; everything else is theirs. The kids compare each clue to the forms, so no real person has to wear, own, or be anything.

Who fills one out

- **The Principal, the Gym Teacher, the Librarian:** send each their script, their answer card, and a blank form together. Forms come back with the videos by [Oct 23].
- **The Custodian:** nothing to do. The form is pre-stamped DECLINED TO COMMENT with the Bureau's "records" printed on it.
- **The Chief (teacher):** fills one out too, from her answer card. It matches every clue. It stays in the Detective's folder until deliberation.

Where they go on the day

- Four forms (not the Chief's) go on the suspect board beside the WANTED posters, from 1:30. Squads can walk over and read them any time.
- The typed summary of the same four forms is the suspect table in every case file, so squads can cross off at their station without leaving it.
- At 2:28, when a squad has crossed off all four, the Detective produces the fifth form. See below.

Form question	Clue that tests it	Answer that gets someone cleared
3. Shoe size	Clue 1 · Evidence Lab: footprint = 27 cm = size 10	The Librarian wrote 7
1. Where at 2:15?	Clue 2 · Ghostbuster Lab: "seen in hall at 2:15"	The Principal wrote "in a meeting"
4. What were you wearing?	Clue 3 · Cipher Room: "snagged my orange sweater"	The Custodian's records say blue
5. Squishies?	Clue 4 · Mummy Witness: the thief loves squishies	The Gym Teacher ticked "don't get them"

The deliberation script (2:28)

A squad says: "Everyone's crossed off." The Detective, loud enough for the room:

"Then your list is too short. Four clues, four facts about the thief. Size 10. In the building at 2:15. Orange sweater. Loves squishies. Who else was in this building yesterday?" *(Let them guess. Someone will say the Chief. The Chief: "I am NOT a suspect.")*

"Chief, you filled out a statement form like everyone else. For completeness. I have it right here." *(Pin it to the board next to the other four. Read it aloud, including the crossed-out "Don't be ridiculous.")* "Detectives, check it against your clues. Then write your warrants."

Optional tell for the sharp ones: the Chief wears something orange all party (a scarf from the bin is fine), and keeps one squishy on her desk, "confiscated."

ANSWER CARD · THE PRINCIPAL

Your Suspect Statement: what to write

Fill out the attached form in your own handwriting. The four answers marked ★ are scripted, because the detectives check them against printed evidence: copy those exactly. The rest are suggestions; write anything you like, and true is funnier. Hand the form back to whoever sent you this by [Oct 23], with your video.

★ **1. Where were you at 2:15?**	In a meeting. A meeting about the next meeting.
2. Who can confirm that?	Everyone at the meeting. All nine of them.
★ **3. Shoe size**	10
★ **4. What were you wearing?**	An orange sweater. School spirit.
★ **5. Squishies?**	Tick LOVE THEM. Explain: “I own ONE. It’s a cat. It’s for stress.”
6. Inside Mrs. Driscoll's room?	Tick DEFINE “INSIDE.”
7. Did you take the Jar?	No. Absolutely not. No.
8. Anything else?	I did not say squishies.

Why these answers: Your meeting alibi is what clears you (Clue 2, the timeline). Everything else keeps you looking guilty, which is the job.

SUSPECT STATEMENT

OFFICIAL

MRS. DRISCOLL'S DETECTIVE BUREAU · CASE #1031 · FORM S-1

Suspect Statement

Answer every question. Print clearly. This will be read by detectives aged nine and ten. They notice everything.

Name _____

Job at this school The Principal

1. Where were you yesterday at 2:15 PM?

_____

_____

2. Who can confirm that?

_____

3. Shoe size (we will check) _____

4. What were you wearing yesterday? Color counts. _____

5. Squishies. How do you feel about them?

☐ Love them ☐ Don't get them ☐ What is a squishy?

_____

6. Have you ever been inside Mrs. Driscoll's room?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Define "inside" _____

7. Did you take the Jar?

_____

8. Anything else the detectives should know?

_____

_____

_____

Signature _____

Date _____

OFFICIAL USE ONLY

Cleared by: ☐ Clue 1 footprint ☐ Clue 2 timeline ☐ Clue 3 orange sweater ☐ Clue 4 witness

ANSWER CARD · THE GYM TEACHER

Your Suspect Statement: what to write

Fill out the attached form in your own handwriting. The four answers marked ★ are scripted, because the detectives check them against printed evidence: copy those exactly. The rest are suggestions; write anything you like, and true is funnier. Hand the form back to whoever sent you this by [Oct 23], with your video.

★ **1. Where were you at 2:15?**	The gym. Where I always am.
2. Who can confirm that?	The dodgeballs.
★ **3. Shoe size**	10
★ **4. What were you wearing?**	Orange. It's a school color. Half the building wears orange.
★ **5. Squishies?**	Tick DON'T GET THEM. Explain: "You squeeze it. It goes back. That's it."
6. Inside Mrs. Driscoll's room?	Tick YES. Add: "To return a kickball. Once."
7. Did you take the Jar?	No. If I wanted to steal something, I'd steal a good jump rope.
8. Anything else?	I just don't understand the obsession these days.

Why these answers: Not getting squishies is what clears you (Clue 4, the witness). Don't soften it.

SUSPECT STATEMENT

OFFICIAL

MRS. DRISCOLL'S DETECTIVE BUREAU · CASE #1031 · FORM S-2

Suspect Statement

Answer every question. Print clearly. This will be read by detectives aged nine and ten. They notice everything.

Name _____

Job at this school The Gym Teacher

1. Where were you yesterday at 2:15 PM?

_____

_____

2. Who can confirm that?

_____

3. Shoe size (we will check) _____

4. What were you wearing yesterday? Color counts. _____

5. Squishies. How do you feel about them?

☐ Love them ☐ Don't get them ☐ What is a squishy?

_____

6. Have you ever been inside Mrs. Driscoll's room?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Define "inside" _____

7. Did you take the Jar?

_____

8. Anything else the detectives should know?

_____

_____

_____

Signature _____

Date _____

OFFICIAL USE ONLY

Cleared by: ☐ Clue 1 footprint ☐ Clue 2 timeline ☐ Clue 3 orange sweater ☐ Clue 4 witness

ANSWER CARD · THE LIBRARIAN

Your Suspect Statement: what to write

Fill out the attached form in your own handwriting. The four answers marked ★ are scripted, because the detectives check them against printed evidence: copy those exactly. The rest are suggestions; write anything you like, and true is funnier. Hand the form back to whoever sent you this by [Oct 23], with your video.

★ **1. Where were you at 2:15?**	Shelving. Alone. In the back. 2:00 to 2:30, every day.
2. Who can confirm that?	No witnesses. That sounded worse than I meant it to.
★ **3. Shoe size**	7
★ **4. What were you wearing?**	My orange cardigan.
★ **5. Squishies?**	Tick LOVE THEM. Explain: “One on every cart. Shelving is stressful.”
6. Inside Mrs. Driscoll's room?	Tick YES. Add: “Overdue books.”
7. Did you take the Jar?	No. If I had, they would be alphabetized by now.
8. Anything else?	Whoever took them... check their feet.

Why these answers: Your shoe size is what clears you (Clue 1, the footprint is a 10). Write 7 whatever your real size is.

SUSPECT STATEMENT

OFFICIAL

MRS. DRISCOLL'S DETECTIVE BUREAU · CASE #1031 · FORM S-3

Suspect Statement

Answer every question. Print clearly. This will be read by detectives aged nine and ten. They notice everything.

Name _____

Job at this school The Librarian

1. Where were you yesterday at 2:15 PM?

_____

_____

2. Who can confirm that?

_____

3. Shoe size (we will check) _____

4. What were you wearing yesterday? Color counts. _____

5. Squishies. How do you feel about them?

☐ Love them ☐ Don't get them ☐ What is a squishy?

_____

6. Have you ever been inside Mrs. Driscoll's room?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Define "inside" _____

7. Did you take the Jar?

_____

8. Anything else the detectives should know?

_____

_____

_____

Signature _____

Date _____

OFFICIAL USE ONLY

Cleared by: ☐ Clue 1 footprint ☐ Clue 2 timeline ☐ Clue 3 orange sweater ☐ Clue 4 witness

ANSWER CARD · THE CUSTODIAN

Your Suspect Statement: what to write

Nothing to fill in. The form is pre-stamped DECLINED TO COMMENT and the Bureau’s own records are printed on it. Sign the bottom if you like. On Oct 30, act shifty in the hallway.

SUSPECT STATEMENT

OFFICIAL

MRS. DRISCOLL'S DETECTIVE BUREAU · CASE #1031 · FORM S-4

Suspect Statement

Answer every question. Print clearly. This will be read by detectives aged nine and ten. They notice everything.

Name _____

Job at this school The Custodian

1. Where were you yesterday at 2:15 PM?

_____

_____

2. Who can confirm that?

_____

3. Shoe size (we will check) _____

4. What were you wearing yesterday? Color counts. _____

5. Squishies. How do you feel about them?

☐ Love them ☐ Don't get them ☐ What is a squishy?

_____

6. Have you ever been inside Mrs. Driscoll's room?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Define inside _____

7. Did you take the Jar?

_____

8. Anything else the detectives should know?

_____

_____

_____

Signature _____

Date _____

Declined to comment

From Bureau records (suspect declined to comment)

Shoe size: **10** (boot closet). At 2:15: **in the building** (sign-in log). Wearing: **blue** uniform, every day. Squishies: **loves them** (seen squeezing one in the boiler room).

ANSWER CARD · THE CHIEF (MRS. DRISCOLL)

Your Suspect Statement: what to write

Fill out the attached form in your own handwriting. The four answers marked ★ are scripted, because the detectives check them against printed evidence: copy those exactly. The rest are suggestions; write anything you like, and true is funnier. Hand the form back to whoever sent you this by [Oct 23], with your video.

★ **1. Where were you at 2:15?**	In my classroom. Teaching. I live here, basically.
2. Who can confirm that?	Twenty children.
★ **3. Shoe size**	10
★ **4. What were you wearing?**	An orange sweater. It's festive.
★ **5. Squishies?**	Write "Don't be ridiculous," cross it out with ONE line so it can still be read, then tick LOVE THEM and write "Fine. Love them."
6. Inside Mrs. Driscoll's room?	Write: "It's MY room."
7. Did you take the Jar?	The Chief is never a suspect.
8. Anything else?	I would like it noted that I am not a suspect.

Why these answers: You match all four clues on purpose. This form stays in the Detective's folder until deliberation (2:28). When a squad has crossed off everyone, the Detective produces it, pins it to the board, and the room turns on you. Keep it off the wall until then.

SUSPECT STATEMENT

OFFICIAL

MRS. DRISCOLL'S DETECTIVE BUREAU · CASE #1031 · FORM S-5

Suspect Statement

Answer every question. Print clearly. This will be read by detectives aged nine and ten. They notice everything.

Name _____

Job at this school The Chief (Mrs. Driscoll)

1. Where were you yesterday at 2:15 PM?

_____

_____

2. Who can confirm that?

_____

3. Shoe size (we will check) _____

4. What were you wearing yesterday? Color counts. _____

5. Squishies. How do you feel about them?

☐ Love them ☐ Don't get them ☐ What is a squishy?

_____

6. Have you ever been inside Mrs. Driscoll's room?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Define "inside" _____

7. Did you take the Jar?

_____

8. Anything else the detectives should know?

_____

_____

_____

Signature _____

Date _____

OFFICIAL USE ONLY

Cleared by: ☐ Clue 1 footprint ☐ Clue 2 timeline ☐ Clue 3 orange sweater ☐ Clue 4 witness